

- **List all your roommates on the lease, and have them all sign it.** Although some landlords won't allow this, it's worth asking about. Having all your roommates listed on the lease ensures that you will all share legal responsibility in case of a problem. It also protects you if one of your roommates suddenly decides to move out before the lease is up. Even if your landlord won't allow you to have all roommates on the lease, you might consider drafting a contract to reflect any agreement you've made among yourselves and getting it signed and notarized. Trouble can happen, and this way if you're left "holding the bag," you have a written document in case you ever need to pursue legal action against your former roommates.
- **Get everything in writing.** Ask for a written lease instead of a verbal agreement. Also, get any additional promises the landlord makes (such as guarantees to paint walls or fix leaky faucets) included in the lease before you sign.
- **Understand how a security deposit works.** A security deposit is money you give to a landlord to protect him in case you damage the apartment or house. If you don't cause any damage, the security deposit will be returned to you when the lease is up. Most states limit the size of a security deposit to one or two months' rent, and many also restrict the ways in which it can be used. In general, the landlord can use the money to fix damages you cause, but not for basic maintenance on the apartment or house.
Get a receipt for the security deposit from the landlord. In some cities, the landlord is required to put your money in an interest-bearing account and pay you the interest at the end of your tenancy. (Even in states that don't require the landlord to pay you interest, some landlords do.) Call your state or local housing office for the rules. When your lease is up and you move out, the landlord must refund your deposit if you haven't caused any damage.
Before you move in, it's a good idea to take pictures of the condition of the apartment and note any issues (no matter